Gamifying the Past through GLAM Engagement and Interactive Heritage in Valete Vos Viatores

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Introduction

Digital technologies are increasingly transforming how cultural heritage is preserved, curated, and communicated to the public. Interactive digital media allows cultural heritage institutions to go beyond static displays and engage audiences in immersive experiences that combine education, exploration, and narrative (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). Valete Vos Viatores: Travelling through Latin Inscriptions across the Roman Empire applies this approach to transform Roman inscriptions, which are traditionally preserved in the form of physical inscriptions and archival records, into an interactive educational game. Developed as part of a collaborative project between universities and cultural institutions, the game situates players in the role of a scriptor titulorum, enabling them to create, interpret, and contextualize Latin inscriptions while exploring reconstructed Roman environments (Andreu Pintado et al. 2022; University of Navarra n.d.). This interactive simulation not only facilitates experiential learning but also demonstrates the potential of digital games to act as tools for public engagement with cultural heritage. By examining how the game's narrative, interactivity, and design choices convey historical knowledge, this essay explores the broader implications of gamifying heritage within the context of Digital Humanities and GLAM practices.

Case Study: Valete Vos Viatores as Interactive Digital Heritage

Valete Vos Viatores: Travelling through Latin Inscriptions across the Roman Empire is an educational video game developed within a broader European research initiative dedicated to the study and dissemination of Roman epigraphy. The project was created through collaboration between academic institutions and cultural heritage organizations, as a great practice of Digital Humanities and GLAM (University of Navarra n.d.). Rather than presenting

inscriptions as static archival objects, the game recontextualizes them within a playable historical environment, transforming inscription scholarship into an accessible public experience (University of Navarra n.d.).

In the game, players take on the role of a scriptor titulorum, responsible for composing and carving inscriptions in the Roman world. Players travel across different regions of the Roman Empire through task-based progression, encountering historical scenarios that require them to interpret, construct, and situate inscriptions within their social and political contexts. Epigraphic heritage is not merely a textual artefact and stone but also a communicative practice embedded in public space through this game design. By simulating the production process of inscriptions, the game highlights the social function of written monuments as tools for memory, identity, and civic expression.

From experience and browsing cultural heritage in person to transform them into a video game that combines different gameplay, this development aligns with broader trends in game-based heritage education, where interactive mechanics are used to enhance cultural understanding and audience engagement (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). Instead of passively receiving information, players actively participate in reconstructing historical context. The spatial exploration of Roman environments further supports interactive learning by situating inscriptions within architectural and urban settings, matching current Digital Humanities approaches that combine with spatial data, visualization, and experiential design.

Recent studies on gamification in cultural institutions emphasize that game mechanics can extend the communicative function of museums and archives by fostering participatory forms of interpretation rather than passive consumption (Bonacini and Giaccone 2022). Digital storytelling in virtual heritage environments has been shown to reconfigure how heritage values are communicated, shifting emphasis from object display to experiential immersion (Shim et al. 2024). Within the broader theoretical landscape, Valete Vos Viatores can be understood as the intersection of GLAM curation and interactive narrative design. The game reshapes prior media forms, such as stone inscriptions, academic documents, and museum exhibits, into an interactive digital environment rather than simply digitizing inscriptions. Cultural heritage is not only represented but reperformed. Such remediation exemplifies how

contemporary digital heritage projects reposition historical knowledge within interactive media systems and the new forms of the relationship between preservation, interpretation, and public engagement.

Narrative Analysis

The narrative communicated in Valete Vos Viatores does not center on a linear quest or a singular protagonist. Instead, the player inhabits the role of a scriptor titulorum, a writer of inscriptions in the Roman world. The game embeds the player within a historical communicative system, and the story is not biographical but cultural.

The progression of the game is guided through structured tasks; these tasks function less as chapters in a dramatic storyline and more as modular engagements with epigraphic practice. The game design aligns with theories of procedural storytelling, in which meaning is conveyed through rule-based systems and player interaction rather than through scripted plot development (Bogost 2007). The mechanics of selecting inscriptional formulas, contextualizing dedications, and situating texts within civic or funerary settings communicate how epigraphy operated socially in the Roman Empire. The rules themselves narrate cultural logic.

Experiential narrative is also an important part of this game. The game requires players to practice Roman commemorative customs rather than tell them about them. This corresponds with experiential models of narrative in digital environments, where meaning is constructed through embodied participation rather than passive reception (Calleja 2011). Each task requires an increasingly nuanced understanding of inscriptional conventions, and the gradual setting of tasks creates a functional narrative. The growing competence of tasks reflects the player's increasing integration into Roman epigraphic culture.

The inscriptions within the reconstructed environment undertake part of the narrative function, which contextualizes history spatially. The environment itself communicates meaning, and inscriptions appear not as isolated texts but as components of lived civic and funerary space. This reflects embedded narrative structures, where narrative elements are distributed across space and artefacts rather than concentrated in dialogue (Jenkins 2004).

The player does not change major historical events; instead, they participate in a system of memory-making. Contemporary research on digital game-based heritage education emphasizes that narrative-driven and identity-based mechanics can enhance cognitive engagement when they simulate cultural processes (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). In this sense, Valete Vos Viatores translates the inscription from the artefact into narrated social action and how societies inscribe memory.

Interactivity

The interactive design includes a structured task system, guided text production, spatial exploration, and simulated inscription practices. The critical question is whether this interactivity functions as superficial click-based learning or as meaningful knowledge construction.

Every task requires the player to interpret contextual information, select appropriate inscription, and consider placement within social space. This aligns with game-based learning, which argues that structured challenge and feedback can enhance historical understanding when mechanics relate to disciplinary thinking (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). The player learns not by memorizing facts but by applying conventions within simulated scenarios. Composing inscriptions requires interpretative decision-making, and the knowledge is strengthened when learning is grounded in action and situated practice. The simulation of inscriptional labor transforms abstract historical information into an enacted procedure through interaction in the digital interfaces. Spatial exploration further reinforces simulation. By navigating reconstructed Roman settings, the player encounters inscriptions within an environmental context. The digital environments allow users to experiment within rule-governed structures that function as model systems rather than merely represent systems. Public discourse surrounding video games and history has emphasized that interactive media can foster historical understanding when they encourage systemic thinking (Laffan and Cassaithe 2020). In Valete Vos Viatores, agency is limited but meaningful; players do not arbitrarily fabricate narratives, they participate in structured cultural reproduction. Knowledge is constructed through action.

Purpose and Intended Impact

The project explicitly situates itself within educational and cultural dissemination frameworks. Developed in collaboration with academic institutions and heritage preservation institutions, it aligns with broader GLAM objectives of making archival and epigraphic material accessible to public audiences. Its stated educational purpose is to promote understanding of Latin epigraphy and Roman cultural practice.

This initiative can be interpreted in two ways. It may be described as entertainment-based education, leveraging gameplay mechanics to enhance engagement. In another way, it may be understood as a curatorial extension of museum practice into digital space. GLAM institutions increasingly utilize interactive technologies to reinterpret archival content for contemporary audiences (Bonacini and Giaccone 2022). Based on this interpretation, the game functions less as commercial entertainment and more as an interactive exhibition. Contemporary commentary on video games and cultural transmission highlights their capacity to mediate complex historical narratives in participatory formats (Brooke 2024). Valete Vos Viatores can be considered the digital form of education mediation based on scholarly epigraphic research.

Audience and Reception

The likely target audience includes students of Latin, classical studies, and history studies, educators, and members of the public interested in Roman history. The design of this game suggests accessibility without oversimplification. While formal reception data is limited, potential effects can be theorized. Research indicates that interactive digital heritage experiences can enhance memory retention by linking information to action (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). The combination of narrative context, procedural engagement, and spatial immersion may strengthen contextual understanding. Furthermore, interactive engagement may support cultural empathy by situating players within historical communicative systems. However, audience impact depends on prior interest and digital literacy. Without the specific background, some users may prioritize completing game objectives over cultural reconstruction.

Critical Evaluation

The translation of Roman epigraphy into a playable system involves abstraction. The question is how and to what extent the simplification of history in Valete Vos Viatores shapes historical understanding. The design of gamification frameworks typically relies on clearly defined objectives, structured rule systems, and measurable feedback mechanics to sustain engagement and progression (Bogost 2007). However, Roman inscription culture was neither uniform nor consistently obeyed the rule in practice. Some formula existed, but the commemorative strategies varied across regions and social classes. When such variability is designed into structured mechanics, differences have the possibility to become standardization in the procedure.

Another critical concern lies in the task completion, which produces a sense of achievement, but it also implies that the epigraphic study will eventually conclude. But uncertainty, fragmentation, and scholarly disagreement are several features in epigraphic study and historical studies. Digital simulation tends to resolve ambiguity into determinate pathways to remain playable. In relation to historical simulations, games often transform complex causality into manageable systems, thereby clarifying patterns while simultaneously constraining interpretative openness (McCall 2016).

There is also a risk of affective smoothing. Interactive systems often align with broader GLAM strategies of audience expansion (Bonacini and Giaccone 2022). However, the desire to make heritage approachable may lessen the discomfort people feel when confronted with the phenomenon of ancient inequalities. If the game foregrounds technical inscription creation while background issues such as slavery, gendered commemoration, or political propaganda, it risks aestheticizing some historical problems.

These critiques do not negate the project's educational value. Rather, they underline the structural tension between playability and complexity. Digital heritage simulations can illuminate cultural systems with clarity, but they inevitably formalize what was historically fluid. The critical challenge is to awareness of the two sides of interpretative act and the reduction in the interactive forms of heritage and balance accessibility with intellectual rigor.

Conclusion

Valete Vos Viatores demonstrates how video games reconfigure Roman epigraphy from a static textual artefact into an enacted cultural process. By positioning the player as a scriptor titulorum, the game shifts narrative emphasis away from individual and toward collective communicative practice.

Its digital format enables forms of interaction that move beyond descriptive heritage display toward simulated engagement, aligning with contemporary approaches in digital heritage and GLAM contexts (Camuñas-García et al. 2024). At the same time, the analysis has identified the tension in translating complex historical practices into rule-based interactive systems. Gamification clarifies the process but may compress the original meaning; video games and simulations enable participation but limit the variety of interpretations. The project, therefore, illustrates both the potential and the limits of interactive digital heritage. Digital platforms can expand access, strengthen contextual understanding, and foster experiential learning. They inevitably formalize and shape the past according to technological and design logics.

Interactive cultural heritage includes the serious video game, do not simply communicate history, but also reconstructs it. Recognizing the reconstructive dimension is essential for critically evaluating the evolving role of digital media in cultural transmission.

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